

Jets to solar planes

Early aircraft were all driven by propellers and mostly flew slowly. Passenger planes also flew low through the clouds, where they were buffeted by air turbulence. The invention of the jet engine in the 1930s changed all that. Jet engines could power planes much faster, high above the clouds in calmer air, and made possible modern air travel, which takes people across continents in just a few hours. Today, scientists continue to develop alternative ways of powering flight.

Jet airliners

- **What?** de Havilland Comet DH 106
- **Who?** Ronald Bishop
- **Where and when?** UK, 1952

In 1952, the de Havilland Comet DH 106, or Comet 1, was the first jet aircraft to go into regular passenger service. It immediately halved the time for long journeys, such as that between the UK and South Africa. Today, there are more than 20,000 jet airliners flying people all around the world.

- ▼ **BOEING 777-300ER**
This typical mid-sized aircraft can carry almost 400 people at once.

The Boeing 777 is the world's biggest twin jet—an aircraft powered by a pair of jet engines.

Wings made mostly of wood



Heinkel He-178 aircraft

First jet plane

- **What?** Heinkel He-178
- **Who?** Hans von Ohain
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1939

The first jet engine was developed in the 1930s by the German scientist Hans von Ohain and the British engineer Frank Whittle, each working independently. Ohain then teamed up in 1935 with German aircraft-maker Ernst Heinkel, who realized that the jet engine could power superfast planes. On August 27, 1939, Heinkel's test pilot made the first successful jet flight.

